

RH03

Early Dynasties of Rajasthan

About 2-3 questions a paper. The Pratiharas and the Ajmer Chauhans are near-certain; the small dynasties - Varika, Mauryas of Chittor, Shivi, Malava - have been asked as one-liners more than once, so do not skip them.

This is the chapter that explains where the Rajput states came from. Tribes and janapadas first, then the Gurjara-Pratiharas as Rajasthan's one imperial power, then the Chauhans of Ajmer who lost at Tarain, and the Guhilas and Paramaras who survived into the medieval period. RPSC mines it for ruler-to-title, ruler-to-work and dynasty-to-capital matching.

Early Dynasties of Rajasthan

Janapadas & republics

- Shivi - Madhyamika/Nagari
- Malava - Nagar, Tonk
- Yaudheyas - Brahmanyadeva
- Arjunayanas
- Rajanyas - Noh
- Nagas of the east

Gurjara-Pratiharas

- Nagabhata I
- Vatsaraja
- Nagabhata II - Kannauj
- Mihir Bhoj - Adivaraha
- Mahendrapala I
- Osian temples

Chauhans of

Shakambhari-Ajmer

- Vasudeva
- Simharaja
- Ajayaraja II - Ajmer
- Arnoraja - Ana Sagar
- Vigraharaja IV
- Prithviraja III - Tarain

Chauhan branches

- Ranthambore - Hammir
- Jalore - Kanhadadeva
- Nadol - Lakshmana
- Sirohi - Deora
- Bundi-Kota - Hada

Guhilas of Mewar

- Guhadatta
- Nagda
- Bappa Rawal
- Atpur inscription 977
- Rawal and Rana lines

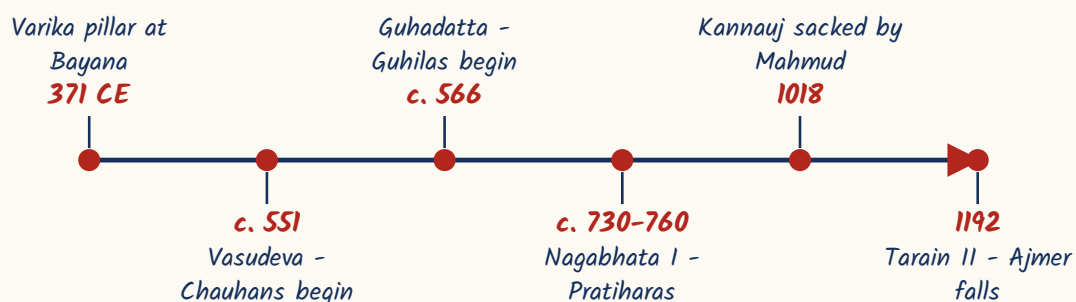
Paramaras & others

- Abu - Chandravati
- Vagad - Arthuna
- Dilwara temples
- Solankis at Kiradu
- Mauryas of Chittor
- Hunas

Before the Rajputs - janapadas, tribal republics and the Nagas

Before dynasties there were tribes, and they left coins. That is the whole point of this section - almost every question here is really a coin-legend question. Learn the legend and the find-spot and you are done.

The dynasties in one line of time



- Shivi or Shibi janapada - capital Madhyamika, which is modern Nagari in Chittorgarh.
- Shivi coins carry the legend Majhamikaya Shibijanapadasa.
- Malava coins read Malavanam Jaya and were found in thousands at Nagar or Karkotanagar in Tonk.
- Yaudheya coins carry Brahmanyadeva, that is Kartikeya.
- Arjunayanas occupied the Bharatpur-Alwar tract; the Rajanyas are known from Noh in Bharatpur.
- The Nagas held eastern Rajasthan; the Hunas under Toramana and Mihirakula raided the north-west in the early 6th century.

Tribe or dynasty to its marker

Tribe / dynasty	Place	Marker
Shivi	Madhyamika - Nagari, Chittorgarh	Legend Majhamikaya Shibijanapadasa
Malava	Nagar / Karkotanagar, Tonk	Legend Malavanam Jaya
Yaudheya	North-western tract	Brahmanyadeva - Kartikeya

Tribe / dynasty	Place	Marker
Rajanya	Noh, Bharatpur	Tribal coinage
Arjunayana	Bharatpur-Alwar	Tribal republic

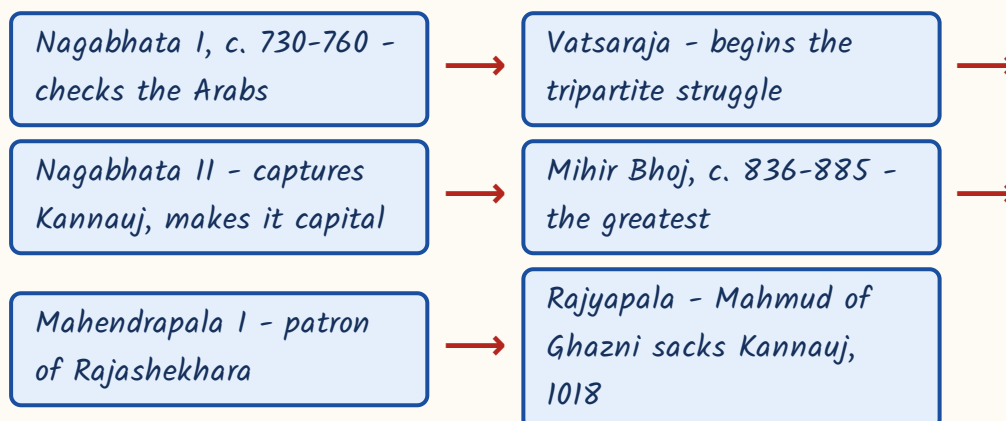
TRAP

Nagari is one place with two identities. As an archaeological mound it is a proto-historic site (RH01). As a political capital it is Madhyamika of the Shivi janapada. The Ghosundi inscription was found nearby. All three facts can be asked about the same dot on the map.

Gurjara-Pratiharas - Rajasthan's one imperial dynasty

The Pratiharas are the only Rajasthan-rooted dynasty that ran a north Indian empire. They start in the Jalore-Bhinmal country in the 8th century, fight the Palas and the Rashtrakutas for Kannauj, win it, and rule from there until Mahmud of Ghazni breaks them in 1018. Learn the sequence of five rulers and their one identifying fact each. That is the whole question set.

Pratihara chronology - learn it in this order



Pratihara ruler to title and identifying fact

Ruler	Title	Identifying fact
Nagabhata I	Nagavaloka	Ruled from Bhinmal / Jalore; checked the Arab advance from Sindh
Vatsaraja	Ranahastin	Opened the tripartite struggle for Kannauj
Nagabhata II	-	Took Kannauj and shifted the capital there
Mihir Bhoj	Adivaraha, on his coins	Gwalior prashasti is his key record
Mahendrapala I	Raghukula-chudamani	Patronised Rajashekhar

- *Rajashekhar wrote Karpuramanjari, Kavyamimamsa, Bala-Ramayana and Bala-Bharata.*
- *The Arab merchant Sulaiman, writing in 851 CE in Silsilat-ut-Tawarikh, called the Pratihara kingdom Juzr.*
- *Sulaiman praised its cavalry and called its ruler the greatest foe of Islam - that ruler was Mihir Bhoj.*
- *The Gwalior inscription praises Nagabhata I as a destroyer of the mlechchhas, that is the Arabs.*
- *Rajyapala did not defeat Mahmud - Kannauj was sacked under him in 1018. That inversion is a standard wrong option.*

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2018 - which Pratihara ruler finally captured Kannauj and made it the capital? Answer: Nagabhata II. Vatsaraja only began the struggle.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - the Arab merchant who in 851 CE described the Pratihara kingdom as Juzr and its ruler as the greatest foe of Islam? Answer: Sulaiman, in Silsilat-ut-Tawarikh.

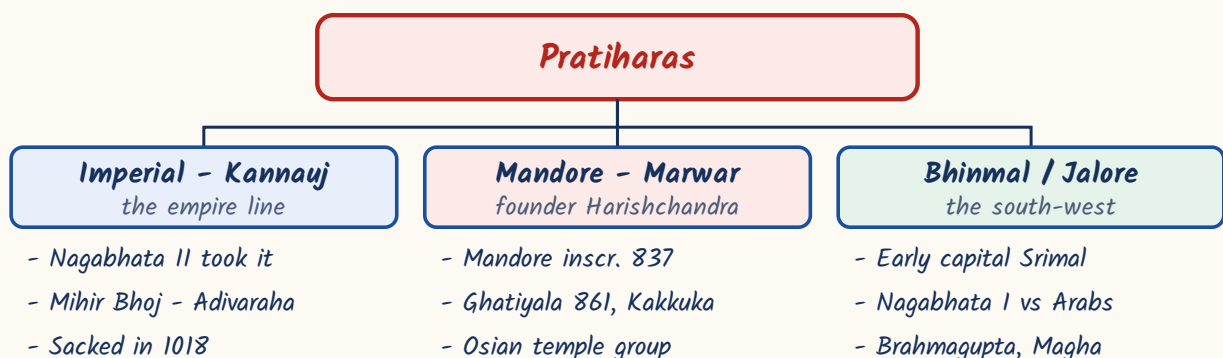
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - Mihir Bhoj has become a live identity question in north India, with statues and Samrat Mihir Bhoj commemorations in Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Haryana and public disputes over community prefixes. For the exam ignore the politics entirely and hold the three facts: title Adivaraha, capital Kannauj, described as Juzr by Sulaiman.

Pratihara branches and monuments

The Pratiharas were not one line but several. Two branches matter - Mandore in Marwar and Bhinmal-Jalore in the south-west - alongside the imperial line at Kannauj. Their temples are the earliest surviving stone temples in Rajasthan, which is why this section leaks into the architecture chapter.

The Pratiharas were not one line



- Harishchandra is regarded as the founder of the Pratihara line of Mandore.
- The Ghatiyala inscription of 861 CE is of Kakkuka and relates to the Pratiharas of Mandore.
- The Mandore inscription of 837 CE belongs to the same group.
- Osian in Jodhpur district has an 8th-11th century Pratihara temple group, including the Sachiya Mata and Mahavira temples.
- Osian is the traditional origin place of the Oswal Jains.
- Bhinmal, also called Srimal, was an early Pratihara capital.
- Bhinmal is traditionally the birthplace of the astronomer Brahmagupta and of the poet Magha, author of Shishupala Vadha.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 - the group of early temples at Osian, largely Pratihara, is in which district? Answer: Jodhpur.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - the Rajor inscription of 960 CE records the building of a Shiva temple by whom? Answer: Mathanadeva, a Gurjara-Pratihara feudatory at Rajorgarh in Alwar; the temple was of Lachchhukesvara Mahadeva. This is the only inscription that actually uses the term Gurjara-Pratihara.

The small-print dynasties RPSC keeps returning to

Do not skip this section because the names look obscure. The Varika dynasty has been asked twice - 2013 and 2021 - which tells you RPSC treats obscurity as a virtue. Each of these gets one line, and one line is all you need.

- Varika dynasty of Bayana - Vishnuvardhana raised the Bijaygarh pillar, locally called Bhim ki Lat.
- That pillar is dated VS 428 = 371-72 CE and records a Pundarika yajna; Vishnuvardhana was probably a Gupta feudatory.
- Mauryas of Chittor - Man Mori built the Man Sarovar; the Man Mori inscription is of 713 CE.
- The Kanaswa inscription of 738 CE in Kota, of Dhavala, also records Maurya rule.
- Bappa Rawal is credited with taking Chittor from the Maurya chief Man Mori.
- Rashtrakutas of Hastikundi - modern Hathundi in Pali - were a local branch of that dynasty.
- Solanki or Chalukya rulers of Gujarat such as Kumarapala and Bhima II controlled Abu and Kiradu; the Kiradu temples are in Barmer district.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - the Bijaygarh pillar inscription of VS 428 records a Pundarika sacrifice by which Varika ruler? Answer: Vishnuvardhana. The same dynasty was asked in 2013 too.

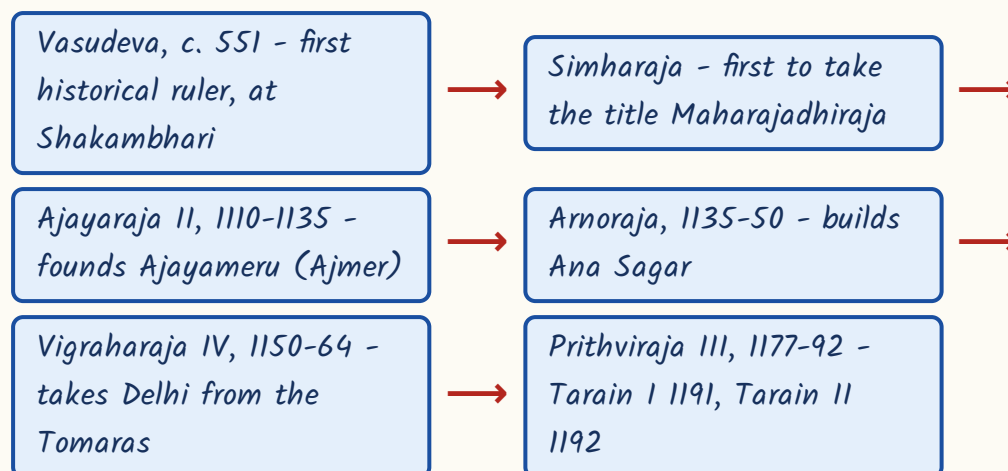
YAAD RAKHO

Bayana carries two separate famous things and they are 1,500 years apart. Bhim ki Lat, the Varika pillar of 371 CE, and the Bayana hoard of Gupta gold coins. If a question says Bayana, check whether it wants the pillar or the coins.

Chauhans of Shakambhari and Ajmer - the main line

The Chauhans, properly Chahamanas, begin at Shakambhari, which is the Sambhar salt-lake country. They shift to Ajmer in the 12th century and end at Tarain. This line gives you rulers who wrote Sanskrit plays and built lakes, and that is exactly the sort of detail RPSC picks.

Chauhan chronology - Sambhar to Tarain



Chauhan ruler to what he is remembered for

Ruler	Remembered for
Vasudeva	First historically attested Chauhan; linked with the Sambhar salt lake
Simharaja	First Chauhan to assume the title Maharajadhiraja
Ajayaraja II	Founded Ajayameru - Ajmer - and shifted the capital; his queen Somaladevi issued coins in her own name
Arnoraja	Built the Ana Sagar lake at Ajmer; defeated Turkish raiders; killed by his son Jagaddeva
Vighraharaja IV (Visaladeva)	Took Delhi from the Tomaras; wrote Harakeli Nataka
Prithviraja III	Beat the Chandela Paramardi in 1182; won Tarain I, lost Tarain II

- The Harsha or Harshnath inscription of 973 CE at Sikar is the earliest surviving record of the Shakambhari Chauhans.
- Vigraharaja IV's court poet Somadeva wrote Lalita-Vigraharaja Nataka in his honour.
- Both plays survive on stone slabs built into the Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer.
- Jayanaka wrote Prithviraja Vijaya; Chand Bardai wrote Prithviraj Raso.
- The Bijolia inscription of 1170 says Ajayaraja founded Ajmer and calls the Chauhans Vatsa-gotra Brahmins.

Tarain I vs Tarain II - the one comparison to hold

First Battle of Tarain, 1191	Second Battle of Tarain, 1192
Prithviraja III wins	Muhammad Ghori wins
Ghori is wounded and withdraws	Prithviraja III is defeated and the Chauhan power at Ajmer ends
No change of capital	Opens the way to Turkish rule in north India

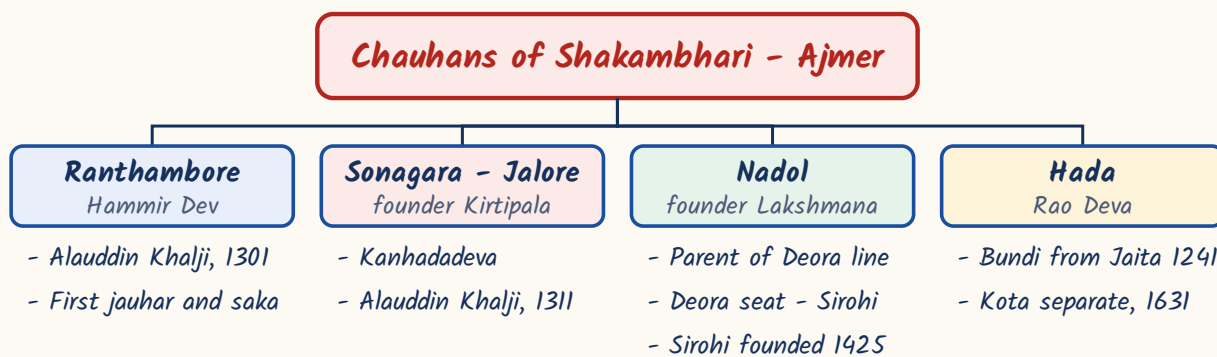
TRAP

Prithviraja III never shifted his capital permanently from Ajmer to Delhi. Delhi was taken by Vigraharaja IV from the Tomaras and held as Chauhan territory; the capital stayed Ajmer. The shifted-to-Delhi statement is a planted false option.

Chauhan branches - who ruled where

After the main line falls, the branches carry on and they are the ancestors of several later princely states. Learn this as a family map: branch name, seat, founder, and the one event attached to it.

The Chauhan branches - the family map



Chauhan branch to seat

Branch	Seat	Founder / key figure	Key event
Main line	Shakambhari, then Ajmer	Vasudeva	Tarain II, 1192
Ranthambore	Ranthambore	Hammir Dev	Defeated by Alauddin Khalji, 1301 - the first jauhar and saka of Rajasthan
Sonagara	Jalore	Kirtipala	Kanhadadeva defeated by Alauddin Khalji, 1311
Nadol	Nadol	Lakshmana, brother of Vakpatiraja I	Parent of the Deora line
Deora	Sirohi	-	Sirohi town founded 1425 by Rao Sahasmal
Hada	Bundi, later Kota	Rao Deva	Took Bundi from Jaita Meena in 1241

- Hammir Mahakavya by Nayanchandra Suri is the source for Ranthambore.
- Kanhadde Prabandh by Padmanabh is the source for Jalore.
- Kota became a separate state under Madho Singh, recognised by Shah Jahan in 1631.
- So Bundi and Kota are both Hada Chauhan - the Hadoti name comes from them.

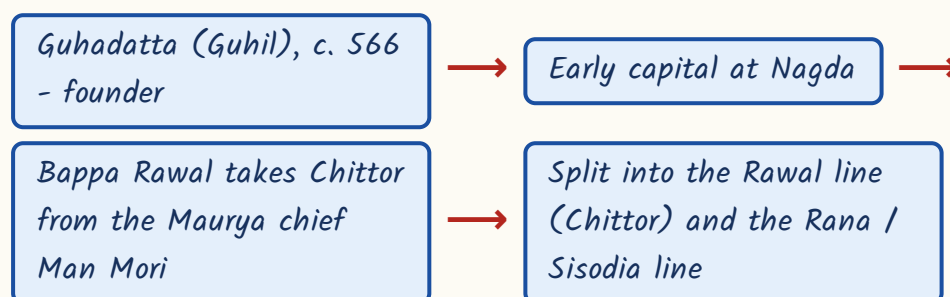
TRAP

Hada Chauhans ruled Bundi and Kota, not Jalore. Jalore is the Sonagara branch. That exact wrong pairing has been used as a NOT-correctly-matched option.

Guhilas of Mewar - the early phase

The Guhilas are the ancestors of the Sisodias, so this section is the doorway into the Mewar chapter. Here you only need the origin story and the inscriptions that prove it. The detailed Mewar history - Ratan Singh, Kumbha, Sanga, Pratap - belongs to the next chapter.

Guhila beginnings



- The Samoli inscription of 646 CE names Shiladitya and gives the earliest evidence of mining in Mewar.
- The Nagda or Aparajita inscription of 661 CE belongs to the same early Guhila group.
- The Atpur or Ahar inscription of 977 CE, of Shaktikumar, gives the Guhila genealogy from Guhadatta.
- The Chirwa inscription of 1273 CE names Jaitrasimha, Tejasimha and Samarasimha; it was composed by Ratnaprabha Suri.
- Bappa Rawal is also called Kalbhoj.

YAAD RAKHO

Two inscriptions, two dynasties, four years apart - and both are genealogies. Harsha 973 CE = Chauhans. Atpur 977 CE = Guhilas. Harsha comes first, alphabetically and chronologically. That pair is match-question bait.

Paramaras, Solankis and the Dilwara temples

Two Paramara branches sat on Rajasthan's south-western and southern edges. Neither was large, but both left buildings, and the buildings are what get asked. The Dilwara temples at Mount Abu are the crossover point between this chapter and the architecture chapter - learn the two main shrines with their builders and dates once, and use them in both.

Dynasty to seat - the early capitals on the map



Pratiharas in the west, Chauhans in the centre and east

- Paramaras of Abu - founder Dhumraj, capital Chandravati.
- Dharavarsha of Abu was a contemporary of Prithviraja III.
- Paramaras of Vagad, that is the Dungarpur-Banswara country, had their capital at Arthuna.
- Vimal Vasahi at Dilwara, 1031 CE, was built by Vimal Shah, minister of Bhima I of Gujarat.
- Luna Vasahi at Dilwara, 1230 CE, was built by the brothers Vastupala and Tejapala.
- Solanki rulers of Gujarat held Abu and Kiradu at various times; Kiradu's temples are in Barmer.

Dynasty to capital - a standing match question

Dynasty	Capital / seat
Paramaras of Abu	Chandravati

Dynasty	Capital / seat
Paramaras of Vagad	Arthuna
Guhilas of Mewar (early)	Nagda
Chauhans of Shakambhari	Sambhar, then Ajmer
Pratiharas (early)	Bhinmal / Jalore
Pratiharas (imperial)	Kannauj
Shivi janapada	Madhyamika (Nagari)

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - two seats from this chapter are inside the Hill Forts of Rajasthan, inscribed by UNESCO in 2013: Ranthambore, the fort of the Chauhan Hammir Dev, and Chittorgarh, taken by Bappa Rawal from the Maurya chief Man Mori. The other four in that serial inscription are Kumbhalgarh, Amber, Jaisalmer and Gagron. If an option links an early-dynasty seat to UNESCO, these are the only two that qualify.

REVISION RECAP

1. Shivi capital Madhyamika = Nagari, Chittorgarh; coin legend Majhamikaya Shibijanapadasa.
2. Malava coins - Malavanam Jaya - found in thousands at Nagar / Karkotanagar, Tonk.
3. Yaudheya coins carry Brahmanyadeva (Kartikeya); Rajanyas at Noh; Arjunayanas in Bharatpur-Alwar.
4. Pratihara order: Nagabhata I - Vatsaraja - Nagabhata II - Mihir Bhoj - Mahendrapala I - Rajyapala (1018).
5. Nagabhata I stopped the Arabs, title Nagavaloka; Vatsaraja title Ranahastin began the tripartite struggle.
6. Nagabhata II took Kannauj; Mihir Bhoj's title was Adivaraha; Gwalior prashasti is Bhoj's key record.
7. Sulaiman, 851 CE, Silsilat-ut-Tawarikh - kingdom called Juzr, ruler the greatest foe of Islam.
8. Mahendrapala I patronised Rajashekhara - Karpuramanjari, Kavyamimamsa, Bala-Ramayana, Bala-Bharata.

9. Mandore branch founder Harishchandra; Ghatiyala inscription 861 CE of Kakkuka; Osian temples in Jodhpur.
10. Rajor inscription 960 CE - Mathanadeva - the only record using the term Gurjara-Pratihara.
11. Varika Vishnuvardhana - Bijaygarh pillar, Bhim ki Lat, VS 428 = 371-72 CE, Pundarika yajna, Gupta feudatory.
12. Chauhans: Vasudeva first, Simharaja first Maharajadhiraja, Harsha inscription 973 CE the earliest record.
13. Ajayaraja II founded Ajmer; Arnoraja built Ana Sagar; Vighraharaja IV wrote Harakeli Nataka and took Delhi.
14. Somadeva wrote Lalita-Vighraharaja Nataka; both plays survive at Adhai Din ka Jhonpra, Ajmer.
15. Prithviraja III - Paramardi 1182, Tarain I 1191 won, Tarain II 1192 lost; Jayanaka wrote Prithviraja Vijaya.
16. Branches: Ranthambore-Hammir 1301, Jalore-Kanhadadeva 1311 (Sonagara, founder Kirtipala), Nadol-Lakshmana, Sirohi-Deora, Bundi-Hada.
17. Rao Deva took Bundi from Jaita Meena, 1241; Kota separate under Madho Singh, recognised 1631 by Shah Jahan.
18. Guhilas: Guhadatta c. 566, capital Nagda, Bappa Rawal (Kalbhoj) takes Chittor from Man Mori; Atpur 977 CE genealogy.
19. Paramaras of Abu - Chandravati, founder Dhumraj; Paramaras of Vagad - Arthuna.
20. Dilwara: Vimal Vasahi 1031 by Vimal Shah; Luna Vasahi 1230 by Vastupala and Tejapala.